

Refunds & Cancellations

A proposed system to handle every cancellation, reschedule, and refund case — for David & Marcel to review and decide on.

Prepared 2026-07-10 · Input: David's operational use-case brief (2026-07-09) + refund policy research · Status: decisions pending, nothing built yet

The short version: none of this exists in the system today — it's the single biggest gap in the whole website. The good news is one shared mechanism (reusing the gift-voucher system we already have working) covers all four of your cancellation cases. We need three decisions from you before it gets built — see page 10.

WHAT'S IN THIS DOCUMENT

PAGE	SECTION
2	Where things stand today & the legal baseline
3	The proposed mechanism, in plain language
4	How it solves your four cases
5	The four proposed flows (diagrams)
9	Cancellation policy — pick a tier (A/B/C)
10–11	Three decisions we need from you
12	Open questions
13	Notes from our conversation

DIAGRAM LEGEND (USED ON PAGES 5–8)

	 Not built yet — this is the proposed design, not current reality
	Decision point in the flow (the system or a person chooses a path)

WHERE THINGS STAND TODAY

Right now, there is **no way to cancel or reschedule a workshop booking** anywhere in the system. If a customer wants to change their date, or Fermentfreude needs to pull a date, it's handled entirely by hand — no dashboard action, no automatic email, and Stripe refunds only ever happen manually inside the Stripe dashboard itself. The app has never once triggered a real refund on its own.

Two smaller things worth knowing before the rest of this document: bookings for a group (1–12 guests) are stored as a single quantity today, not as named individual seats — so there's no way yet to cancel just one person's spot out of a group booking. And the downloadable voucher PDF has a display bug where it always shows a fixed placeholder amount instead of the real value purchased — a small, separate fix (see page 4, Mini-Case).

THE LEGAL BASELINE — YOU HAVE MORE FREEDOM HERE THAN YOU MIGHT EXPECT

Under EU/Austrian consumer law (§18 FAGG, confirmed by the CJEU for dated leisure bookings), **workshops booked for a specific date are exempt from the statutory 14-day withdrawal right**. The shop is very likely exempt too, since fermented food counts as rapidly perishable. In plain terms: **Fermentfreude is not legally required to refund a booking if a customer changes their mind**.

That means the cancellation policy below (page 9) is entirely a business and brand-trust decision — not a compliance requirement. This is genuinely liberating, but also means "we could just say no refunds ever" is legally fine while likely feeling wrong for a health-conscious, community-oriented audience. *This is not legal advice — before publishing any policy wording, it should get a quick pass from a lawyer or the WKO advisory service, since exact wording matters for enforceability.*

ONE EXCEPTION WORTH FLAGGING

If the shop ever sells anything **non-perishable** (a cookbook, dry goods, merchandise), that product would **not** be covered by the perishable-goods exemption, and the standard 14-day withdrawal right would apply to it. Worth a mental note for later — see the open questions on page 11.

THE PROPOSED MECHANISM, IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

Instead of building three separate systems for "give someone a new date," "give someone a credit," and "give someone their money back," we propose **one shared mechanism** that all four of your cases plug into. The core idea:

1. Reuse the gift-voucher system as a "booking credit"

You already have a fully working voucher system: unique codes, a status field (active/redeemed/expired), a euro value, redemption at checkout, a PDF, and an automatic Brevo email. A cancellation credit is functionally the same thing — a stored value tied to a code. Rather than building something new, an affected booking gets issued a voucher automatically, wrapped in a friendly "magic link" so the customer doesn't have to dig up a code. This is the fastest option to build well, because it reuses code that already works in production today.

2. Give each seat in a group booking its own status

Today a booking for 3 people is one row with no way to mark just one of the three as cancelled. We'd upgrade each seat to carry its own status (active / cancelled / rebooked / credited / refunded / no-show). This is real but contained schema work, and it becomes the shared foundation all four cases sit on — including the "one friend drops out of a group of three" case.

3. Build the first real Stripe refund — with a human in the loop

When cash does need to go back (last resort, see the waterfall below), the dashboard calculates a suggested refund based on your cancellation policy, and shows it to David or Marcel for a one-click confirm before Stripe actually moves any money. Nothing happens automatically to a customer's payment without a person approving it first.

The shared principle behind every flow on the next few pages: try rebooking first, offer credit second, and only fall back to a cash refund as the last resort. This keeps revenue in the business, matches how comparable workshop operators handle it (cooking-class industry research, page 9), and avoids paying a card-processing fee twice.

HOW THIS SOLVES YOUR FOUR CASES

CASE 1

Fermentfreude cancels a whole workshop date

Every affected booking gets a magic link to self-serve a new date. Payment stays linked to the customer — nothing auto-refunds. If no date works for them, credit is offered first, cash refund only if they insist. Admin can always rebook manually as a fallback. *See diagram, page 5.*

CASE 2

One customer reschedules, the workshop still runs

Self-service magic link from the original confirmation email lets them pick a new date for the same workshop type, gated by a rebooking window and available capacity. Same payment, no new charge. Admin handles the rare edge case (price difference, expired link) manually. *See diagram, page 6.*

CASE 3

Customer cancels entirely (no date works for them)

This is where the policy tiers on page 9 plug in directly: how many days before the workshop determines whether they're offered full credit, partial credit, or nothing — with cash refund always the last-resort option, reviewed by an admin before it fires. *See diagram, page 7.*

CASE 4

One person out of a group booking cancels

Depends on Decision 2 (page 10) — once seats carry their own status, removing one person is the exact same rebook → credit → refund waterfall as Case 3, just scoped to that one seat's proportional value instead of the whole booking. MVP is admin-only; self-service can come later. *See diagram, page 8.*

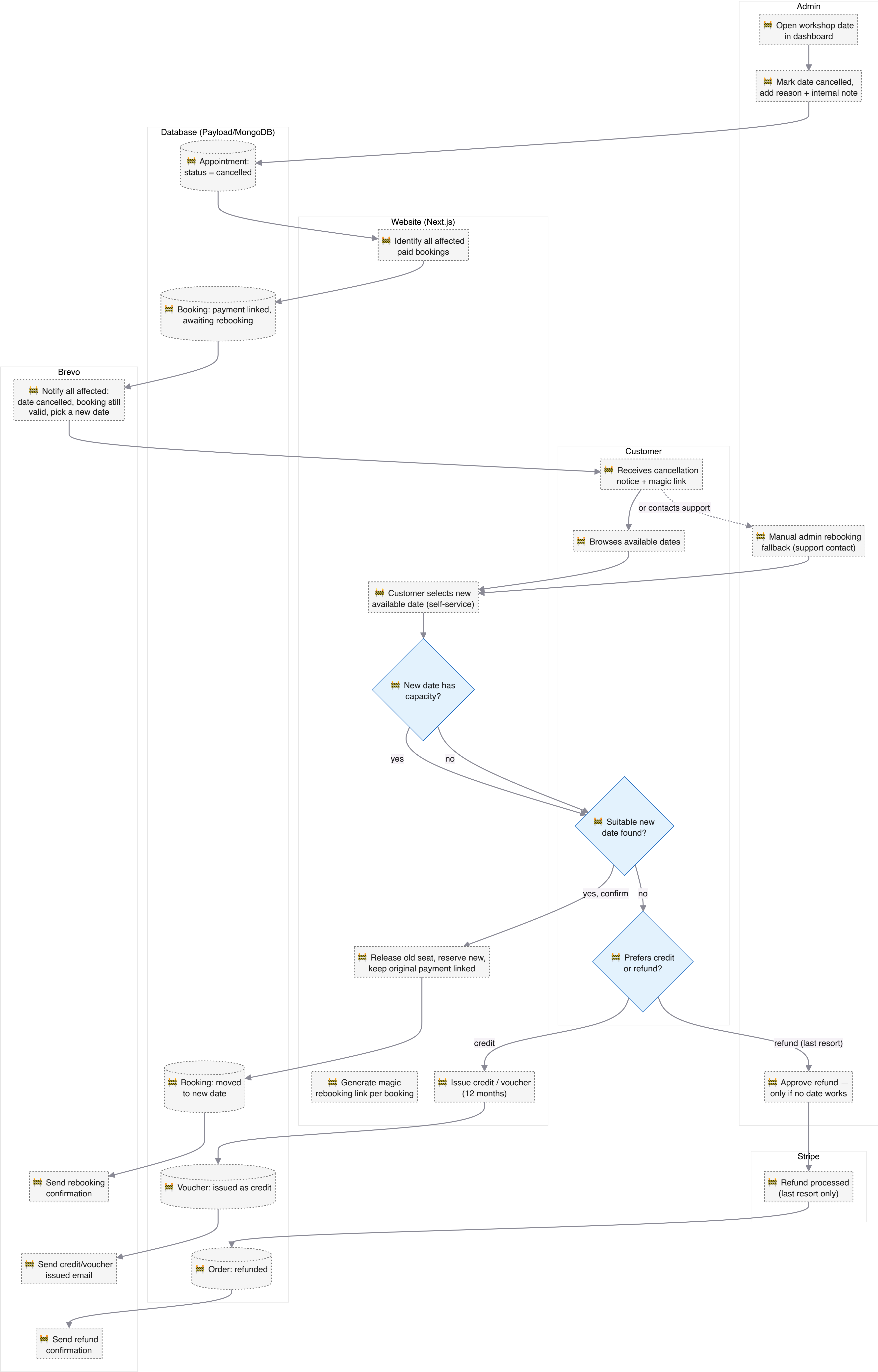
MINI-CASE

PDF voucher shows the wrong amount

Separate, small, confirmed bug — not part of the cancellation system. The PDF generator stamps the code onto a static template but the visible euro amount is baked into the template artwork, not read from the real voucher value. Contained fix, no policy decision needed.

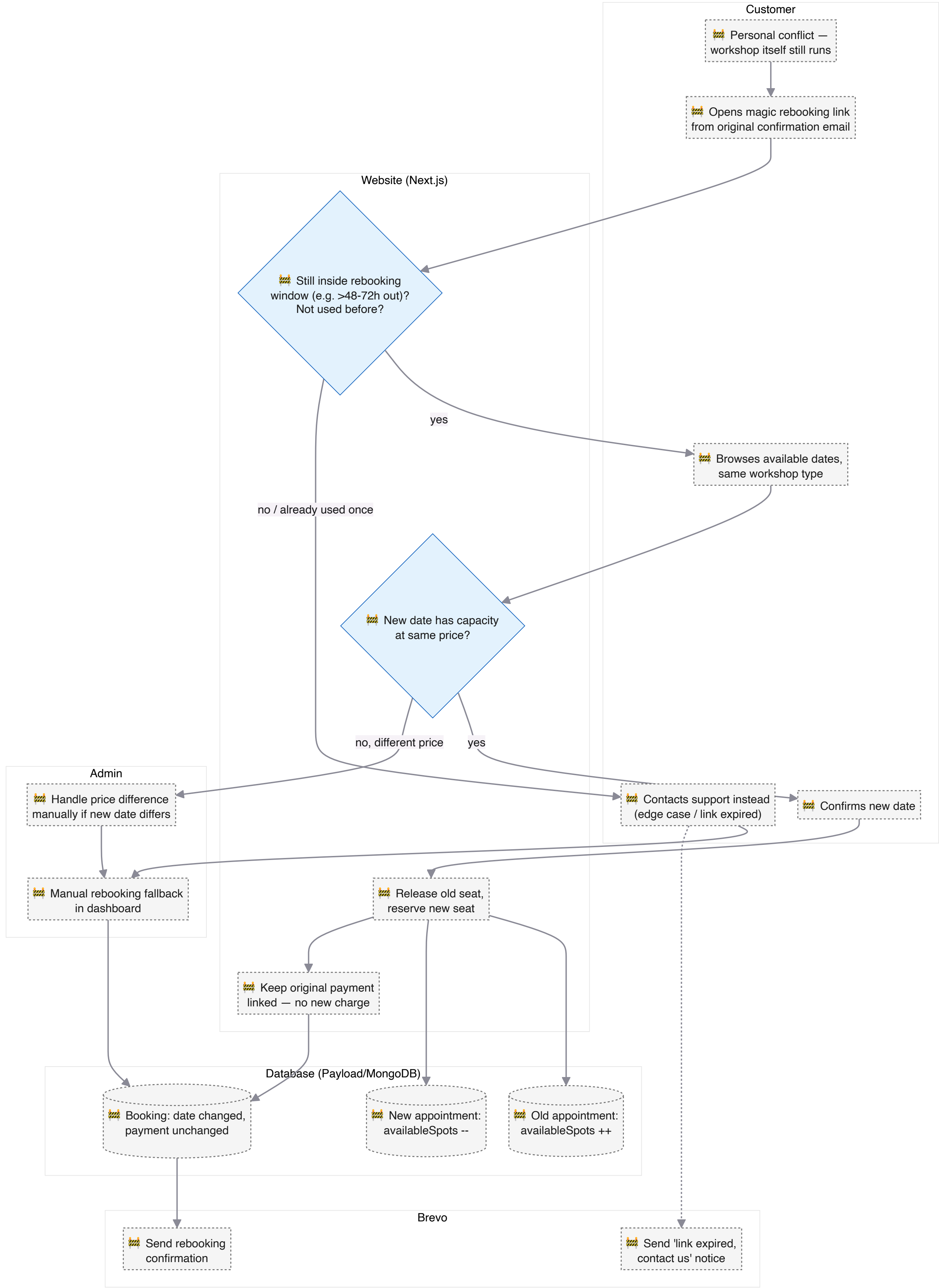
Flow 11a — Admin cancels a full workshop date (David's Case 1)

Illness, scheduling conflict, or too few participants force a whole date to be pulled. Payments stay linked to the customer (nothing auto-refunds); everyone affected gets a magic-link invite to self-serve a new date, with manual admin rebooking as the fallback. Refund is offered only if no date works for the customer.



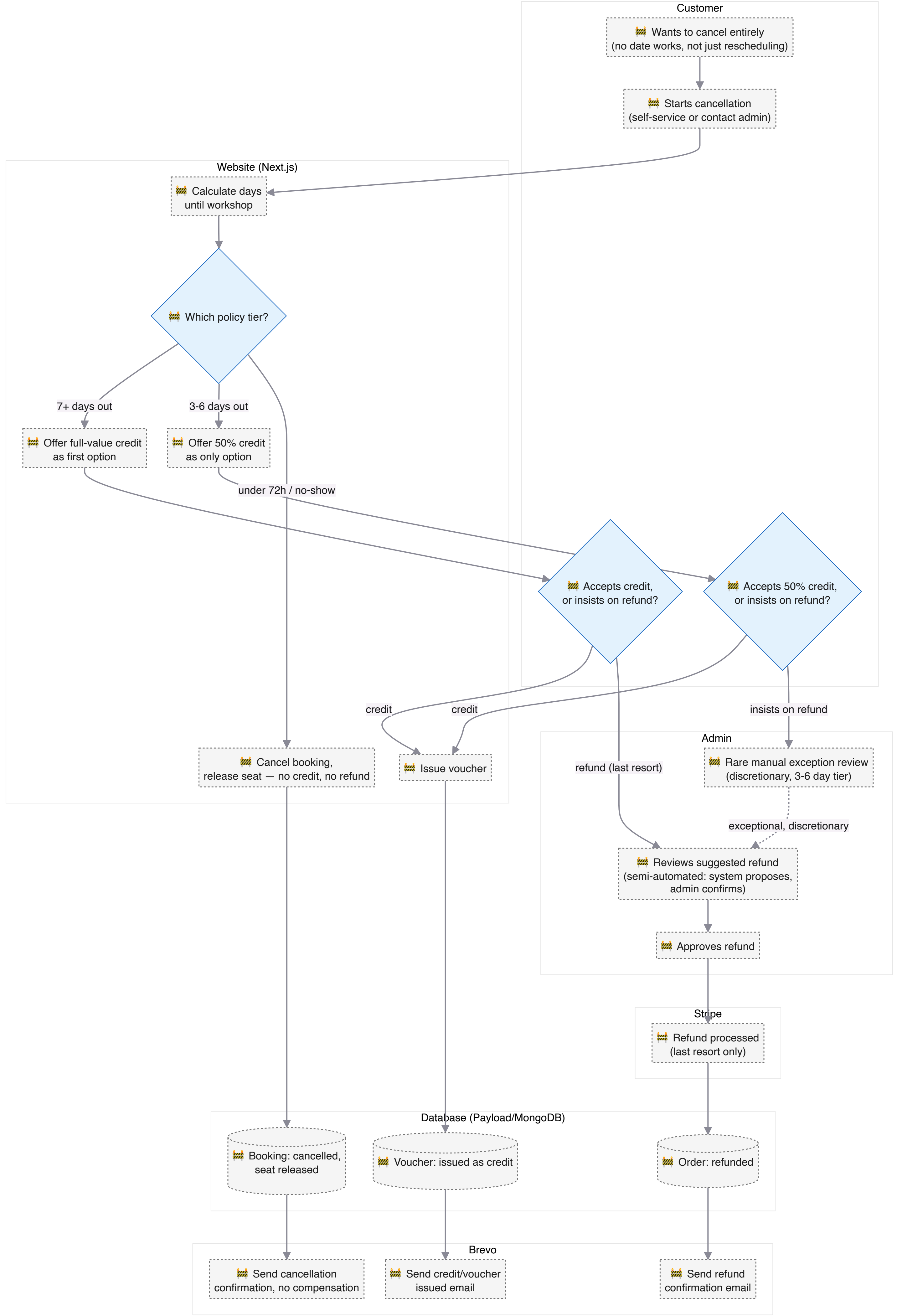
Flow 11b — Individual reschedule, workshop unaffected (David's Case 2)

One customer has a personal conflict; the session itself still runs for everyone else. Self-service via a magic link in the original confirmation email, capacity- and window-gated, with admin manual rebooking as the fallback for edge cases (expired link, price difference).



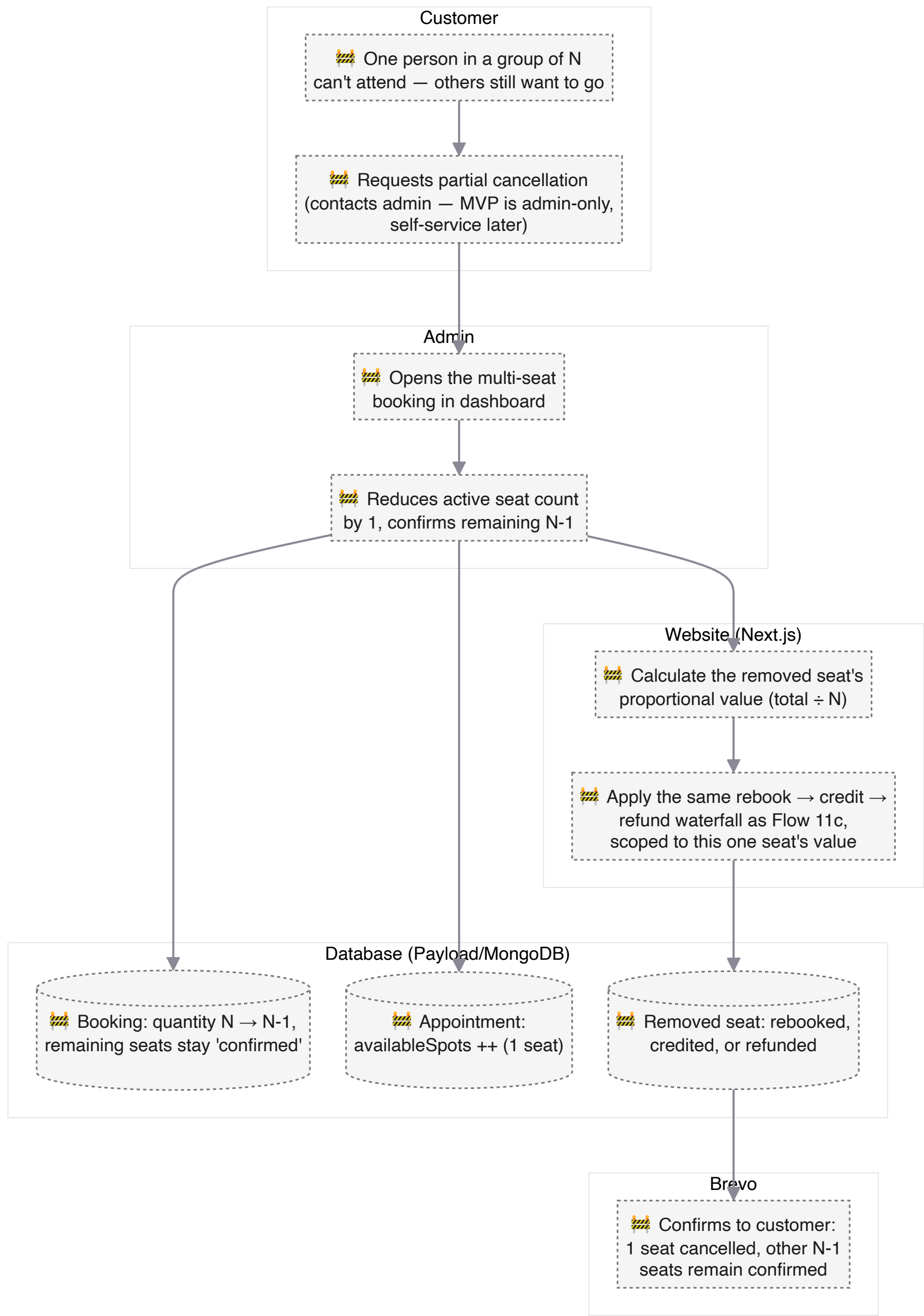
Flow 11c — Customer cancels entirely: rebook → credit → refund waterfall (David's Case 3)

The customer doesn't want any date — a true cancellation. Resolution depends on the same policy tiers proposed in the refund policy doc: 7+ days out offers credit first (refund only if the customer insists), 3–6 days offers credit only (refund becomes a rare, discretionary admin exception), under 72h/no-show gets neither.



Flow 11d — Partial cancellation of a multi-seat booking (David's Case 4)

Bookings hold 1–12 guests as a single quantity, not named individuals — so "one person out of a group of 3" reduces the quantity by one rather than cancelling the whole booking. MVP is admin-only (per David's suggested Option C); self-service can come later. The single removed seat's value follows the exact same rebook → credit → refund waterfall as Flow 11c, just scoped to one seat instead of the whole booking.



🚧 **Not built:** none of Flow 11a–11d exists today — the single biggest gap versus every flow above. These are the intended shapes, not current reality, and still need David & Marcel's sign-off on the underlying refund/credit policy before they're built as-is.

CANCELLATION POLICY

PICK A TIER — HOW STRICT SHOULD THE POLICY BE?

Comparable workshop / cooking-class businesses (same dynamics: perishable ingredients, capacity limits, instructor time booked in advance) converge on a tiered window. Three coherent starting points, at different points on the strictness spectrum:

☐ **A — Strict** protects margin, lowest admin overhead

No refunds once booked; date changes only, up to 48–72h before, subject to availability. No-shows forfeit fully.

☐ **B — Balanced** closest to the cooking-class norm — recommended starting point

Full refund 7+ days out. Voucher/credit only inside 7 days. No refund or credit inside 24–48h or on a no-show.

Transfers to another person always allowed, free, at any time. Generous enough to build trust without exposing the business to last-minute losses — a good fit for a health-conscious, repeat-visit-likely audience.

☐ **C — Generous** brand-trust-first

Full refund up to 24–48h out, voucher beyond that. Only no-shows forfeit. Costs more in absorbed ingredient/capacity loss, may fit a premium positioning.

None of this is legally required (see page 2) — pick whichever tier fits how you want the brand to feel. Write in exact day/hour cutoffs and any tweaks below.

DECISIONS NEEDED BEFORE THIS GETS BUILT

THREE QUESTIONS FOR DAVID & MARCEL

DECISION 1 — COVERS CASES 1, 2 & 3

How should a customer reclaim money from a cancelled or changed booking?

☐ **One booking credit, two doors in** **RECOMMENDED**

Reuse the existing gift-voucher system as a single credit mechanism — customers redeem it with a code or a personal link. Fastest to build well, most reuse of existing working code.

☐ **Three separate systems**

Build rebooking code, magic link, and account-based credit as genuinely distinct features. More flexible in theory, three times the work to build and maintain.

☐ **Admin-only for now**

Skip customer self-service entirely. David/Marcel move bookings manually — doesn't reduce support workload.

DECISION 2 — COVERS CASE 4

Should each seat in a group booking get its own status, starting now?

☐ **Give every seat its own status now** **RECOMMENDED**

Real but contained schema work now. Becomes the shared foundation Cases 1–4 all sit on.

☐ **Keep it simple, handle by hand for now**

No new schema work now, but partial cancellations stay a manual, error-prone workaround indefinitely.

DECISION 3 — COVERS CASE 3

How automated should the cash refund be?

This is the first time the system would ever trigger a real Stripe refund itself — today that only happens by hand in the Stripe dashboard.

☐ **System suggests, you confirm** RECOMMENDED

Dashboard calculates a suggested refund per your cancellation policy; nothing happens to the customer's money until David or Marcel confirms.

☐ **Fully manual**

Dashboard just records the decision — refund, credit, or nothing — amount typed in by hand each time.

☐ **Fully automatic**

System applies the policy and issues the refund/credit with no human in the loop.

SUGGESTED BUILD ORDER, ONCE DECIDED

STAGE	WHAT
1 — Foundation	Booking-credit mechanism, seat-level status, refund action, fix the appointment-capacity race condition
2 — Core flows	Cases 1–4 (the four diagrams in this document)
3 — Self-service	Customer-facing redemption / magic links
4 — Lower priority	Case 5 hardening, Press/Media CMS section, PDF voucher amount fix

BEFORE FLOW 11 GETS BUILT

OPEN QUESTIONS WORTH ANSWERING DIRECTLY

These came up during the research and aren't fully resolved by the decisions above — quick answers here save a mid-build interruption later.

- ☐ **Group bookings (1–12 guests):** if one person in a group of 4 cancels, is that a partial refund for 1 seat, or all-or-nothing for the whole booking?

Not addressed by any comparable-business example we found — needs an explicit answer. (Feeds Decision 2 / Case 4.)

- ☐ **Admin-initiated cancellation (Case 1):** confirm this should always be a full refund or full credit, customer's choice — worth confirming that's uncontroversial.

Different logic than a customer-initiated cancellation, where the policy tier (page 9) applies.

- ☐ **Voucher expiry for compensation credits:** same expiry as a purchased gift voucher, or something more generous?

A customer being compensated for a cancellation arguably deserves more lenient terms than someone who bought a gift.

- ☐ **Shop — anything non-perishable?** Books, merch, dry goods? If yes, that product line needs its own separate return clause.

The perishable-goods legal exemption (page 2) won't cover non-perishable items.

MEETING NOTES

NOTES FROM OUR CONVERSATION

Space for whatever comes up while going through this together — decisions made, numbers agreed, follow-ups.